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SECURITY



Google says hackers
stole its customers' data
by breaching its
Salesforce database

Google has confirmed that some customers' information has been stolen in a recent breach of one of its databases.

In a [blog post](#) late on Tuesday, Google Threat Intelligence Group said one of its Salesforce database systems, used to store contact information and related notes for small and medium-sized businesses, was breached by a hacking group popularly known as ShinyHunters, formally designated as UNC6040.

"The data retrieved by the threat actor was confined to basic and largely publicly available business information, such as business names and contact details," the company said.

Google did not disclose how many customers are affected, and Google spokesperson Mark Karayan declined to comment beyond the company's blog post. It's not clear if the company has received any communication, such as a ransom demand.

ShinyHunters is known for targeting big companies and their cloud-based databases.

This is the latest in a series of breaches targeting Salesforce cloud systems, after recent thefts of [customer data from Cisco](#) and [airline giant Qantas](#), [retail giant Pandora](#), among others, as [reported by Bleeping Computer](#). According to Google's blog post, the ShinyHunters group relies on voice

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phishing techniques to trick company employees into granting them access to their cloud-based Salesforce databases.

Google said the ShinyHunters group is likely preparing a data leak site, which some ransomware gangs use to publish stolen data to [extort their corporate victims](#) into paying a ransom. The group is said to have overlaps with other groups, [including The Com](#), a known collective of cybercriminals who use hacking, extortion, and sometimes threats of violence to break into networks.

Do you know more about the Google data breach? Have you been notified by Google? Securely contact this reporter via encrypted message at [zackwhittaker.1337](#) on Signal.

Updated with response from Google.

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Ransomware attack blamed for Change Healthcare outage stalling US prescriptions

Zack Whittaker — 11:26 AM PST · February 26, 2024

IMAGE CREDITS:

TIFFANY HAGLER-GEARD / BLOOMBERG / GETTY IMAGES

An ongoing cyberattack at U.S. health tech giant Change Healthcare that [sparked outages and disruption to hospitals and pharmacies across the U.S. for the past week](#) was caused by ransomware, TechCrunch has learned.

A healthcare executive with knowledge of the incident, who was on the call briefed by the company's executives, said the healthcare tech giant attributed the cyberattack to the BlackCat ransomware group.

[Reuters first reported the news](#) linking the cyberattack to BlackCat, citing two people familiar

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with the incident.

A spokesperson for Change Healthcare did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

BlackCat, also often referred to as ALPHV, has not yet publicly claimed responsibility for the cyberattack. Ransomware and extortion gangs typically publish portions of a victim's stolen data to extort a ransom demand. Ransomware attacks typically scramble a victim's files and demand a ransom to receive the decryption key. Newer cyberattacks often involve cybercriminals stealing a victim's data before encrypting it.

It's not yet known if patient data was stolen in the ransomware attack.

UnitedHealth Group (UHG), the parent company of Change Healthcare and the largest U.S. health insurance provider, said in a government regulatory filing last week that it [identified a "suspected nation-state" threat actor in its systems](#), but did not attribute the cyberattack to a specific government or state.

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The accuracy of UHG's cyberattack attribution remains unclear, as cybersecurity researchers have not previously linked the BlackCat gang to a nation-state or government.

Change Healthcare is an American healthcare tech giant and one of the country's largest processors of prescription medications, handling prescriptions and billing for more than 67,000 pharmacies across the U.S. healthcare system. The company handles 15 billion healthcare transactions annually — or about one in three U.S. patient records.

Change Healthcare merged with healthcare provider Optum in 2022 as part of a \$7.8 billion deal under UnitedHealth Group. The deal allowed Optum broad access to patient records handled by Change Healthcare.

UnitedHealth Group collectively provides over 53 million U.S. customers with benefit plans and another 5 million outside of the United States, according to [its latest full-year earnings report](#). Optum serves about 103 million U.S. customers.

The cyberattack at Change Healthcare [began on February 21](#) early on the U.S. East Coast, causing widespread outages at pharmacies and healthcare facilities. Change Healthcare said it took much of

its systems offline to expel the hackers from its systems.

Change Healthcare's [incident tracker page](#) shows nearly all of its customer-facing systems remain offline.

Hospitals, healthcare providers and pharmacies have reported that they are unable to fulfill or process prescriptions through patients' insurance.

The American Hospital Association (AHA), which represents more than 5,000 hospitals and healthcare providers, told [its members in a notice last Friday](#) to "consider disconnection from Optum until it is independently deemed safe to reconnect," and warned of "significant cascading and disruptive effects" caused by the cyberattack.

Columbia University, which runs one of New York's largest hospitals, told staff on Friday to [disconnect all its systems](#) from UnitedHealth Group, Change Healthcare and Optum and blocked access to their email domains.

Tricare, the U.S. military's health insurance provider for active military personnel, said [in a statement](#) that the cyberattack at Change Healthcare is "impacting all military pharmacies worldwide and some retail pharmacies nationally."

BlackCat/ALPHV have previously taken credit for cyberattacks targeting [U.S. healthcare giant Norton](#), [news-sharing site Reddit](#), and [mortgage and loan giant Fidelity National Financial](#).

Do you work at LoanDepot and know more about the incident? You can contact Zack Whittaker on Signal and WhatsApp at +1 646-755-8849, or [by email](#). You also can contact us via [SecureDrop](#).

US health tech giant Change Healthcare hit by cyberattack



U.S. healthcare technology giant Change Healthcare has confirmed a cyberattack on its systems. In a brief statement Wednesday, the company said it was “experiencing a network interruption related to a cyber security issue.” “Once we became aware of the outside threat, in the interest of protecting our partners and patients, we took immediate action to ... Continue reading

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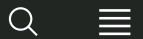
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Change Healthcare stolen patient data leaked by ransomware gang

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documents, including billing files, insurance records and medical information.

Some of the files, which TechCrunch has seen, also contain contracts and agreements between Change Healthcare and its partners.

RansomHub threatened to sell the data to the highest bidder unless Change Healthcare pays a ransom.

It's the first time that cybercriminals have published evidence that they have in their possession medical and patient records from the cyberattack.

Zack Whittaker
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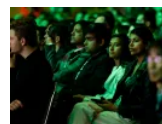
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For Change Healthcare, there's another complication: This is the second group to demand a ransom payment to prevent the release of stolen patient data in as many months.

UnitedHealth Group, the parent company of Change Healthcare, said there was no evidence of a new cyber incident. "We are working with law enforcement and outside experts to investigate claims posted online to understand the extent of potentially impacted data. Our investigation remains active and ongoing," said Tyler Mason, a spokesperson for UnitedHealth Group.

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What's more likely is that a dispute between members and affiliates of the ransomware gang left the stolen data in limbo and Change Healthcare exposed to further extortion.

A Russia-based ransomware gang called ALPHV [took credit for the Change Healthcare data theft](#). Then, in early March, ALPHV suddenly disappeared along with a \$22 million ransom payment that Change Healthcare allegedly paid to prevent the public release of patient data.

An ALPHV affiliate — essentially a contractor who earns a commission on the cyberattacks they launch using the gang's malware — went public claiming to have carried out the data theft at Change Healthcare, but that the main ALPHV/BlackCat crew stiffed them out of their portion of the ransom payment and vanished with the lot. The contractor said the millions of patients' data was “still with us.”

Now, RansomHub says “we have the data and not ALPHV.” Wired, which first [reported the second group's extortion](#) effort on Friday, cited RansomHub as saying it was associated with the affiliate that still had the data.

UnitedHealth previously declined to say whether it paid the hackers' ransom, nor did it say how much data was stolen in the cyberattack.

The healthcare giant said in a statement on March 27 that it obtained a dataset “safe for us to access and analyze,” which the company obtained in exchange for the ransom payment, TechCrunch learned from a source with knowledge of the ongoing incident. UHG said it was “prioritizing the

review of data that we believe would likely have health information, personally identifiable information, claims and eligibility or financial information.”

As the Change Healthcare outage drags on, fears grow that patient data could spill online



A cyberattack at U.S. health tech giant Change Healthcare has ground much of the U.S. healthcare system to a halt for the second week in a row. Hospitals have been unable to check insurance benefits of in-patient stays, handle the prior authorizations needed for patient procedures and surgeries or process billing that pays for medical ... [Continue reading](#)

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US sanctions LockBit members after ransomware takedown

Zack Whittaker — 7:45 AM PST · February 20, 2024



The U.S. government has sanctioned two key members of LockBit, the Russian-speaking hacking and extortion gang accused of launching ransomware attacks against victims across the U.S. and internationally.

IMAGE CREDITS: KELVIN CHAN / AP

In a post on Tuesday, the U.S. Treasury confirmed it is sanctioning two Russian nationals, Artur Sungatov and Ivan Gennadievich Kondratiev.

Sungatov and Kondratiev [were separately indicted by U.S. prosecutors on Tuesday](#) for their alleged involvement with LockBit.

Kondratiev is also accused of involvement with REvil, RansomEXX and Avaddon ransomware gangs.

“The United States will not tolerate attempts to extort and steal from our citizens and institutions,” said U.S. Deputy Secretary of the Treasury Wally

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Adeyemo [in a statement](#). “We will continue our whole-of-government approach to defend against malicious cyber activities, and will use all available tools to hold the actors that enable these threats accountable.”

The newly imposed sanctions mean it is now illegal for U.S. businesses or individuals to pay or otherwise transact with those named by sanctions, a tactic typically used to discourage American victims from paying a hacker’s ransom.

Sanctioning the individuals behind cyberattacks makes [it more difficult for the individual hackers to profit from ransomware](#), rather than targeting groups that can rebrand or change names to skirt sanctions.

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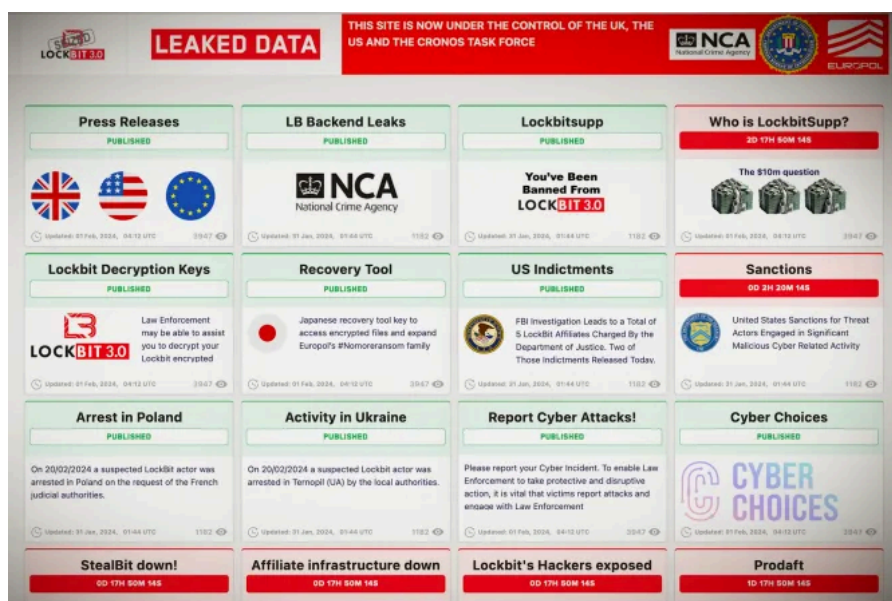
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Those who are caught violating U.S. sanctions law, such as companies paying a sanctioned hacker, can lead to hefty fines and criminal prosecution.

The sanctions dropped hours after U.S. and U.K. authorities announced [a global law enforcement operation aimed at disrupting LockBit's infrastructure and operations](#). The authorities announced the seizure of LockBit's infrastructure on the gang's own dark web leak site, which the group [previously used to publish victims' stolen data](#) unless a ransom was paid.



A SCREENSHOT OF THE NOW-SEIZED LOCKBIT LEAK SITE.

IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH (SCREENSHOT)

U.S. prosecutors accuse LockBit's operators of using ransomware in more than 2,000 cyberattacks against victims in the U.S. and worldwide, making some \$120 million in ransom payments since it was founded in 2019.

LockBit has taken credit for hundreds of hacks over the years, including [California's Department of](#)

[Finance](#), the [U.K. postal service Royal Mail](#) and [U.S. dental insurance giant MCNA](#), affecting millions of individuals' personal information.

The U.S. sanctions announced Tuesday are the latest round of actions targeting the hackers behind LockBit and other prolific ransomware gangs.

In 2022, Russian-Canadian dual national [Mikhail Vasiliev was arrested](#) on allegations of launching multiple LockBit ransomware attacks. A year later, U.S. authorities [arrested Ruslan Magomedovich Astamirov](#) under similar allegations. Both suspects remain in custody awaiting trial.

A third suspect, Russian national Mikhail Pavlovich Matveev, was accused of involvement in several ransomware operations, including LockBit.

Matveev, who remains at large, was [subject to U.S. sanctions in 2023](#), preventing U.S. victims from paying a ransom to him or his associated ransomware gangs, [including Hive and Babuk](#). The U.S. government also has a \$10 million reward for information leading to Matveev's arrest.

In its announcement Tuesday, the U.S. government did not yet name the suspected LockBit ringleader, who goes by the moniker LockBitSupp. The now-seized LockBit dark web leak site says law enforcement plans to release more information on the alleged leader on Friday, including details of a \$10 million bounty for information leading to their location or identification.

Besides sanctions, the U.S. does not ban or otherwise restrict victims from paying a ransom, though the FBI has long advised victims against paying off hackers for fear of perpetuating future cyberattacks. Security researchers say that ransomware victims who pay a ransom are [more](#)

[likely to experience subsequent ransomware attacks.](#)

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[Why are ransomware gangs making so much money?](#)

[Why ransomware victims can't stop paying off hackers](#)

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[Why extortion is the new ransomware threat](#)

Authorities disrupt operations of notorious LockBit ransomware gang



A coalition of international law enforcement agencies, including the U.S. Federal Bureau of Investigation and the U.K.'s National Crime Agency, have disrupted the operations of the

notorious LockBit ransomware gang. LockBit's dark web leak site — where the group publicly lists its victims and threatens to leak their stolen data unless a ransom demand is ...

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